

A.J. Walker

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Anchor Point Studios (NetEase)

Design Director, March 2025 - Current

Unannounced 3rd Person Multiplayer Action Game (PC, Consoles) (Unreal Engine 5)

- Provided feedback, direction, and career guidance to a fully remote international team of 14 game designers, from associates to leads, across Level Design, Live Ops Design, Technical Design, UI Design, and Combat Design (Enemy AI, 3C's, Character Abilities, Balance).
- Owned and delivered features for a complete combat loop and progression loop by providing constant support to multi-departmental feature teams through pitches, design documentation, Jira organization, playtesting, feedback, and final polish reviews.
- Outlined detailed feature plans for 4 major development milestones by prioritizing gameplay features and communicating with the Creative Director, as well as with Art, Engineering, Narrative, and Production Directors.
- Delivered a vertical slice build, and 3 follow-up alpha builds, each with hours of highly-replayable gameplay that yielded positive reviews from internal stakeholders as well as from external playtesters.
- Individually ideated and documented over 40 confluence pages for a wide variety of gameplay features, including procedurally generated level systems, combat mechanics, interactive objects, player abilities, player progression, cosmetics, loot systems, and post-launch engagement beats.
- Individually implemented, through over 100 perforce changelists, a variety of new design content, features, and bug fixes in UE5 using Blueprint and GAS.

Hi-Rez Studios

Design Director, June 2023 - March 2025

SMITE 2 (PC, Xbox Series, PS5) (Unreal Engine 5)

- Managed 10+ game designers across Combat Design, Level Design, Game Balance, Systems Design, Monetization teams, as well as the entire UI Design Team.
- Led multi-departmental feature teams from early development to the free-to-play launch of an action 3rd-person MOBA that reached over 21,000 concurrent players on Steam.
- Delivered over 13 live updates during Early Access with a focus on player engagement and long term retention, leading to a consistent and sustainable CCU for the game.
- Scoped and directed a variety of SMITE 2 features: 4 unique game modes, 45+ Playable Gods, in-game HUD, frontend UI, item store, ability tooltips, player mastery systems, player cosmetics, and the new player experience.
- Communicated and put into action our core design philosophies and processes.
- Implemented playable character abilities, item effects, and UI-driven systems using UE5 tools such as Blueprint and GAS, including the first new playable character for SMITE 2: Hecate, and over 50 unique Moba Items.
- Gathered feedback and created action items from public testing sessions with SMITE 1 players, Hi-Rez Devs of all departments, and external focus groups.
- Authored and publicly presented product goals, gameplay update notes, and design processes to the SMITE community via written articles, video content, and live streams.

Design Director, Jan 2020 – June 2023

SMITE (PC, Xbox, PlayStation, Nintendo Switch) (Unreal Engine 3)

- Managed 10+ game designers across Combat Design, Level Design, Game Balance, Systems Design, Monetization teams, as well as the entire UI Design Team.
- Strategically planned and executed live-service game updates that met internal goals and broke our CCU and Monetization personal records multiple times over several years, while remaining in the top 10 highest-selling free-to-play games on Steam, Xbox, and PlayStation.
- Analyzed player data through proprietary tools and gathered player feedback through multiple Discord servers and social media channels to improve internal decision-making.
- Created pitch decks, mood boards, and design documentation to convey design direction or to communicate complete design details for 40+ unique playable characters and 80+ monthly launches with a wide array of live service game features of various sizes.
- Advised Art and Monetization teams working on cosmetic items to ensure cohesive themes, engaging gameplay, and player excitement, including multiple crossover IP projects like Avatar: The Last Airbender, Magic: The Gathering, and Teenage Mutant Ninja Turtles.
- Authored monthly developer commentary articles and appeared on monthly developer live streams with 3k+ viewers to deliver clear and accurate design goals to our players.
- Outlined narrative plot points and directed both writing staff and voice actors for 7 years of monthly updates.

Lead Designer, May 2016 – Jan 2020

SMITE

Game Designer, Sep 2015 – May 2016

SMITE

Gameloft NYC

Game Designer, Aug 2013 – July 2015

Disney Pixar's Cars: Fast as Lightning (iOS and Android) (Proprietary Engine)

- Designed the racing gameplay and progression systems by tuning variables and managing economy calculations in XML and Excel.
- Built all of the game's racetrack levels (15+ tracks) in Gameloft's proprietary editor, and created asset lists for environment art teams and gameplay programming teams for modular design.

Education

University of Central Florida: Master's Degree in Game Design, FIEA program

- Led a 15-person capstone project game that shipped to iOS and Android: Pitch Jumper
- Designed and implemented multiple playable prototype games in Unreal, Unity, Javascript, and Flash as a solo dev or with groups of 4-5 people.

University of Florida: Bachelor's Degree in Environmental Engineering